COMMUNICATION SKILLS II

MEIC & METI

WEEK 3

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY & TEAMWORK:
GROUP COMMUNICATION DYNAMICS THAT MAKE TEAMS WORK

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TODAY’S CLASS

Theory

- Psychological Safety
- Internal Communication and Coordination Costs
- Teams Roles and Norms
- Groupthink Prevention

Active Practice

- Meeting Lab
- Team Charter

Artifact

- Meeting Decision Log
- Team Charter

AKNOWLEDGMENTS

Elaborated also with materials from lectures by previous Teachers: Sofia Sá and Claudia Silva.

START QUESTIONS

In your last group project, how many times did you not say something you thought—because it felt risky?

Would you rather be on a team where nobody argues… or a team where people disagree openly and fix mistakes fast?

What’s the fastest way to break a team: lack of skill… or fear of looking stupid?

TODAY’S CLAIM

THE BEST TEAMS AREN’T CONFLICT-FREE — THEY’RE SAFE ENOUGH TO DISAGREE AND CORRECT ERRORS.

- The **strongest predictor of team failure** isn’t conflict — **it’s fear**: fear of looking incompetent, fear of being punished, fear of being ignored.
- **Great teams don’t avoid conflict** — they make it safe to surface problems early.
- **Psychological safety enables “learning behaviors”**: asking for help, admitting mistakes, questioning decisions, and correcting errors before they scale.
- When safety is low, teams drift into silence and false consensus (**groupthink** - agreement without scrutiny), which produces **poor decisions** (“quiet failure”).

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

IS

Is a shared belief in a team that it is safe to take interpersonal risk: ask questions, admit uncertainty, raise problems and disagree.

- It’s a team climate, not a personality trait (you can be a introvert and still have psychological safety.
- It’s respect and learning orientation: people can challenge ideas without social punishment.
- This concept comes from Amy Edmonson’s work on team learning.

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

IS NOT

- “being nice all the time”
- lack of accountability or standards
- avoiding hard conversations
- absence of mistakes and different opinions

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

WHY IT MATTERS?

Psychological safety predicts error correction and team learning behaviors such as:

- asking for help
- admitting mistakes
- discussing problems early
- experimenting and improving processes

Impacts:

- fewer silent failures;
- faster debugging.

SPEAK UP

WHY SMART PEOPLE STAY SILENT?

People often withhold “voice” because speaking up carries risks:

- looking incompetent
- annoying people
- being seen as negative/disruptive
- upsetting hierarchy/status

Evidence example:

Research on employee voice shows leadership behaviors like openness are linked to people speaking up, and psychological safety helps explain that relationship *(James R. Detert, Ethan R Burris)*.

Teams don’t fail only from lack of skill. They fail because concerns stayed private.

INTERNAL COMMUNICATION

= COORDINATION UNDER INTERDEPENDENCE

- **Internal communication** is mostly coordination: managing dependencies between tasks.

- Teams exist because **work has interdependencies** (one person's output becomes another's input).

- Coordination theory frames coordination as **managing those interdependencies** through processes, roles, and information flow.

When we improve **communication norms**, we're reducing dependency failures: waiting, rework, misunderstandings

COORDINATION COSTS

WHY TEAMS GET “SLOWER” AS THEY GROW?

Productivity isn’t just “sum of talents.” **Teams lose performance through process losses** (inefficiencies that subtract from what the team could do):

- coordination losses (misalignment, work duplication, waiting)
- motivation losses (reduced effort / diffusion of responsibility)

In software engineering, Frederick P. Brooks Jr. famously captured the intuition: adding people increases communication overhead and can delay progress.

NORMS AND ROLES

THE INVISIBLE “OPERATING SYSTEM” OF TEAMS

- **Norms** = shared expectations about behavior (how we disagree, how we decide, how we ask questions).

- **Roles** reduce coordination cost by clarifying “who owns what” and how information travels (e.g., facilitator, note-taker, timekeeper).

- Norms and roles reduce coordination costs because they make behavior predictable and ownership clear.

In practice:
A simple team charter can improve satisfaction and performance in student teams.

INTERACTION QUALITY

BEATS “BEST INDIVIDUAL”

Research on collective intelligence finds **group performance across tasks is linked less to the max IQ of members and more to interaction factors** like:

- more equal conversational turn-taking
- higher social sensitivity (noticing others)

Implication:
Domination and silence are performance problems, not just “communication style” or personality quirks (Anita Williams Woolley).

GROUPTHINK

WHEN HARMONY BECOMES A BUG

Irving Janis described **groupthink** as a pattern where pressures for consensus lead to defective decision-making. Symptoms include:

- self-censorship (“better not say it”)
- illusion of unanimity (“no one objected, so everyone agrees”)
- pressure on dissenters
- mindguards (blocking contrary info)

Groupthink happens when the pressure to agree becomes stronger than the pressure to think.

GROUPTHINK

EVIDENCE-BASED PREVENTION

The fix isn't 'argue more.' The fix is designing dissent into the process.

To prevent groupthink and increase speak-up:

- Assign a **devil's advocate / red-team** role (someone must find risks).
- Use **round-robin** speaking turns (equalize airtime).
- Do "**write-first**" before discussion (better idea generation; less dominance).
- Hold a "**second-chance**" check: "What could make this decision wrong?"
- **Document decisions**: decision → rationale → owner → deadline (reduces coordination loss)

ACTIVE PRACTICE

ACTIVITY 1

MEETING LAB

Goal: feel the coordination costs and the impact of dominance/silence/groupthink risk, then fix it with structure.

Setup: solo + groups of 5-6.

Steps:

1. Write-first (5 min)
2. Round 1 Meeting (10 min)
3. Debrief with Observer Checklist (10 min)
4. Fix Protocol
5. Round 2 Meeting (10 min)

SOLO (5 MIN)

Your team must decide today between two technical options under constraints (time + reliability).

Option A: quick fix, faster delivery, higher technical debt risk
Option B: robust fix, slower delivery, lower risk

You must:
Write preferred option (A/B) + 1 reason + 1 risk

DEBRIEF WITH OBSERVER CHECKLIST (10 MIN)

Each group uses the checklist to score itself quickly (0/1 per item).

- Where did we lose time or clarity? (coordination costs)
- Who spoke most/least? Why?
- Did we reach a real decision or just ‘stop talking’?

DEBRIEF WITH OBSERVER CHECKLIST (10 MIN)

Each group uses the checklist to score itself quickly (0/1 per item).

- **Goal stated** clearly (what decision are we making?)
- **Constraints stated** (time/quality/risk)
- **Turn-taking**: everyone spoke at least once
- **Dissent surfaced** (at least 1 disagreement voiced)
- **Red-team raised risks**
- **Decision was explicit** (not implied)
- **Owner + deadline** were assigned
- **Next checkpoint** defined
- **Decision documented** in writing
- Tone stayed **respectful** (no dismissive language)

FIX PROTOCOL

Meeting Rules for Round 2

- **Goal + constraints** in 30 seconds
- **Round-robin**: everyone speaks once (30–45 sec each)
- **Red-team** must raise 2 risks
- **Decision + owner + deadline + next checkpoint**
- Document it (**Decision Log**)

ROUND 2 MEETING

5-6 GROUPS + ROLE ASSIGNMENT

Re-Run the Group Meeting, applying Fix Protocol (10 min)

- **Roles:**
  a. **Facilitator** (keeps structure)
  b. **Note-taker** (fills Decision Log)
  c. **Challenger/Red-team** (must raise risks)
  d. **Timekeeper**
  e. **Contributors** (everyone speaks)

Everyone must speak at least once!

ARTIFACT

MEETING DECISION LOG

PURPOSE:
MAKE IT EASY TO SPEAK UP, DISAGREE PRODUCTIVELY, COORDINATE EFFICIENTLY, AND LEAVE MEETINGS WITH CLEAR OUTCOMES

MEETING DECISION LOG

AGENDA → DECISION → OWNER → DEADLINE

01

Before the meeting

- **Decision needed:** What are we deciding today?
- **Why now:** What is happening? What triggered this decision?
- **Constraints:** time / quality / risk

MEETING DECISION LOG

AGENDA → DECISION → OWNER → DEADLINE

02

Discussion Agenda

A. Align on facts (2–3 min)

- What do we know (data)? What is uncertain?

B. Define success criteria (2 min)

- What does “good enough” look like?

C. Options + tradeoffs (5–10 min)

- Option A / B (C if needed)
- Pros/cons; costs; risks; dependencies

D. Risks + assumptions (2–4 min) (Red-team leads)

- Key assumptions that must be true
- Dissent/concerns raised
- Early warning signals

E. Decision (2 min)

- Decide using the chosen rule (consensus / vote / lead-decides-after-input)

MEETING DECISION LOG

AGENDA → DECISION → OWNER → DEADLINE

03

Written Output

Decision: _____

Rationale (1–2 sentences): _____

Assumptions: _____

Risks + mitigation: _____

MEETING DECISION LOG

AGENDA → DECISION → OWNER → DEADLINE

04

Action Plan (so work happens)

- **Owner: _____**
- **Deadline: _____**
- **Next checkpoint: _____ (date/time)**
- **Where documented: _____ (ticket/doc link)**

05

Final Alignment
(“Second-chance” questions, groupthink prevention)

- Is anyone not on board or seeing a risk we haven’t named?
- What’s one thing we should watch to know early if we’re wrong?

ACTIVITY 2

TEAM CHARTER

Goal: build practical speak-up behavior and turn it into team norms.

Setup: same groups of 5-6.

Steps:

1. Speak-Up (15 min)
2. Build Team Charter (20 min)
3. Gallery Walk (10 min)

SPEAK-UP (15 MIN)

ROLE-PLAY | Practice 3 “interpersonal risk” behaviors

1. **Each person makes a 1 minute attempt.**
2. **Other group members give feedback.**
3. **Rotate.**

A) Raise a risk

- “I might be wrong, but I’m seeing a risk: ___. Can we check it before we commit?”
- “What could make this plan fail?”

B) Disagree and commit

- “I see it differently because ___. Can I share a concern and then support the final decision?”
- “If we choose X, I suggest we mitigate risk Y by ___.”

C) Ask for help / admit uncertainty

- “I’m not fully confident about ___. Can someone sanity-check this with me?”
- “I may be missing context—what’s the key constraint here?”

BUILD TEAM CHARTER (20 MIN)

Convert practice into norms. Fill a one-page charter.

A) Norms that create safety

- How we disagree (rules)
- How we ask questions / admit uncertainty
- How we give space to quieter members

B) Roles

- Facilitator, note-taker, red-team, timekeeper (rotation plan)

C) Meeting rules

- Round-robin first pass
- Decision log required
- “Second chance” question: What could make this wrong?

D) Escalation ladder

- If stuck after 10 minutes: pause → write-first → call a brief break

E) Banned phrases

- “That’s basic.” “Stop being emotional.” “Always/never.” etc.

GALLERY WALK (10 MIN)

Post your Charter

Half the teams stay as hosts; half circulate.

Circulators leave two comments on two other groups using:

- One norm we want to steal is…
- One possible failure point is… (groupthink/dominance/silence risk)
- One improvement suggestion is…

ARTIFACT

TEAM CHARTER

PURPOSE:
MAKE IT EASY TO SPEAK UP, DISAGREE PRODUCTIVELY, COORDINATE EFFICIENTLY, AND LEAVE MEETINGS WITH CLEAR OUTCOMES

TEAM CHARTER

Norms that create psychological safety

- We challenge ideas, not people.
- We assume good intent until evidence suggests otherwise.
- We ask clarifying questions early ("help me understand…"). Questions are always welcome.
- We treat mistakes as information: problem-solving over blame.
- Everyone contributes: round-robin first pass; no interruptions. Everyone speaks at least once in key-decisions.
- We explicitly invite dissent: "What are we missing?"
- We use "write-first" when stuck or dominated by fast speakers.
- When tension rises, we name the process and reset.

Dissent and decision rules

- Use "disagree and commit": voice concerns, then support the final decision.
- Always run a risk check: "What could make this wrong?"
- Decision rule is explicit (consensus / vote / lead-decides-after-input).
- Every decision gets logged (rationale + owner + deadline).

Escalation ladder

Pause → write-first → short break → ask for neutral facilitation → escalate.

Banned language

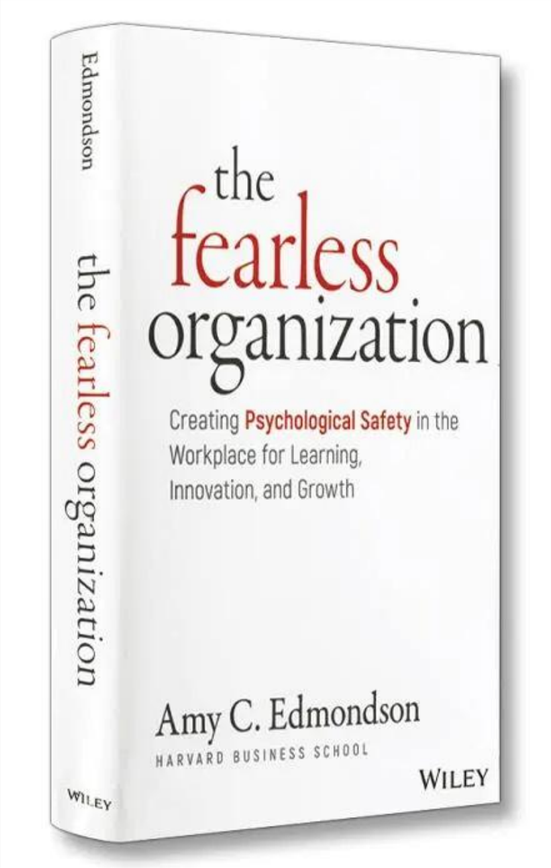
No shaming, labeling, sarcasm, "always/never," or competence attacks.

READING SUGGESTIONS

READING SUGGESTION

It explains how psychological safety works as a team climate that enables learning behaviors (speaking up, asking questions, admitting mistakes) and why that matters for performance in complex, uncertain work.

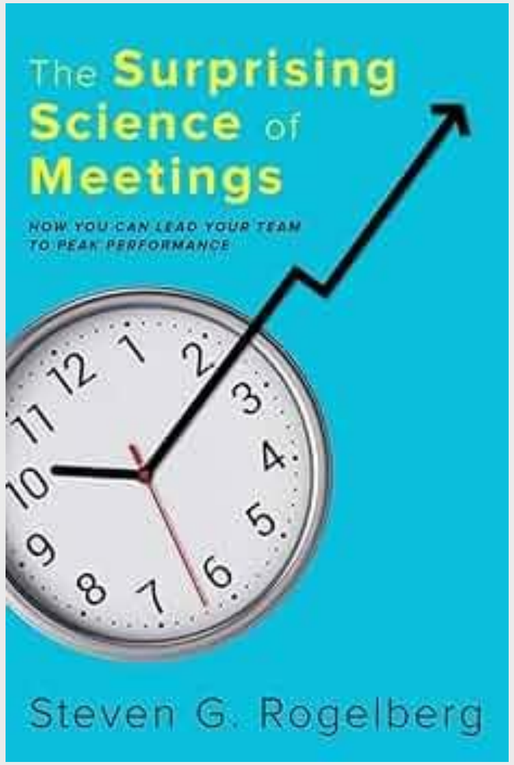
Best parts for this week class: the practical guidance on how leaders and teams create safety through everyday norms (how meetings run, how errors are handled, how dissent is invited).



READING SUGGESTION

An evidence-based approach to making meetings effective: why meetings fail, how structure changes participation, and which small design choices reduce waste and improve decision quality.

Best parts for this week class: the sections on improving meetings by changing participation patterns (less dominance, more inclusion), which connect to psychological safety.



THANK YOU